Eye-catching terracota artefacts from Rishi Valley

MADRAS

The setting is ideal, despite the snarling traffic around. Under the spreading banyan tree and close to a small Vinayaka shrine on the campus of Adyar Park hotel in a perfectly aesthetic atmosphere, are displayed the exquisite terracota products from the famed Rishi Valley area, near Madanapalle town, in Chittoor district of Andhra Pradesh.

The products in pottery are wide-ranging and bewitching: over-sized silos for storing paddy or ragi, big ornamental pots with side-slits for growing flowering plants, terracota horses, bigger Mother Goddess figurines, cooking pots, decorative water-jugs, trays for growing bonsai plants etc. The exhibition, which is open from February 5 to 9 and organised by the Crafts Council of India, "is an endeavour to locate, for the potters, an appreciative market which values the rustic beauty of terracota.'

The exhibition itself forms part of a larger project which aims at boosting the craft activities of the villagers living around Rishi Valley, thus providing an alternative source of income and precluding their necessity to migrate to towns in search of more viable employment.

Even a glimpse at the terracota artefacts displayed makes the legend of Rishi Valley, with its Bodiconda, Koruconda and Horseley Hills forming the backdrop, come alive. The products are from the potters belonging to a cluster of villages of the Valley area: Thettu, Kothapalle, Kantevaripalle, Mandavarepalle, Angallu etc. Mr.Vadlamudi Narayana, whose products have been displayed in the exhibition, points to some unusual products of his own: the exquisitely designed "magic' water jug with holes at the bottom through which you pour water into the jug but still the water does not flow out, terracota bells emitting a nice sound, which can be conveniently used as calling-bells, again water-jugs with holed protruberances for a thin rope to pass through so that the jug can be hung from the shoulder etc. The storage silos come in two varieties: bottoms closed and those without bottoms, the latter generally fixed to a wooden or cement plank. While these store paddy or ragi, smaller pots in diminishing size are kept on top of them for storing dhal, groundnuts, chillies, jaggery etc. There are separate pots for storing tamarind.

In the middle of the exhibition format is placed the figure of Goddess Ammavaru, the deity protecting the village, to appease whom the villagers conduct annual festivals and offer sacrifices of goats, hens etc.

Mrs. Gita Ram, Honorary Secretary of Crafts Council of India, says the organisation was at the moment organising such promotional activities where the buyer-seller contacts could be forged directly. The CCI had already done a documentation on ritual designs like kolams and tattoo-marks.

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